
Respectfully, Bill Gates Should Shut Up

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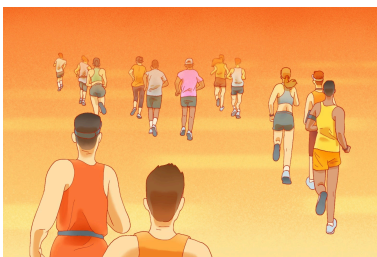
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On Tuesday, as the strongest Atlantic storm in 90 years slammed the western coast of Jamaica with 185-mph winds, Bill Gates was downplaying climate change. In a lengthy blog post published on his personal website, Gates purported to offer some “tough truths about climate” ahead of next week’s United Nations climate conference. Railing against a “doomsday outlook” stemming from “much of the climate community,” the [author of 2021’s *How to Avoid a Climate Disaster*](#) claimed that there’s “too much” emphasis on “near-term emissions goals” as opposed to addressing “poverty and disease.” (The straight line between climate disasters from higher temperatures and [the acceleration](#) of both [poverty](#) and [disease](#) went unnoted.) While Hurricane Melissa—whose ferocity was supercharged by ocean waters [heated by carbon-emissions absorption](#), as well as increased atmospheric moisture—laid waste to much of Jamaica, Gates [followed up with a CNBC interview](#), excusing Microsoft’s fossil-fueled A.I.-construction surge and reiterating that global warming “has to be considered in terms of overall human welfare.” (He didn’t touch on the many ways artificial intelligence itself [has damaged human welfare](#).)

The billionaire [does not appear](#) to have publicly addressed the disaster in Jamaica that’s since [extended throughout the Caribbean](#), with Melissa having killed dozens across Cuba, Haiti, the Bahamas, and the Dominican Republic. And his overall point, frankly, does not hold up to scrutiny.

Gates isn’t alone; climate change has slipped down the world’s priority list in the past few years—and it shows. [Governments](#) and [corporations](#) are shelving emissions goals, budgets are being redirected from climate initiatives [to warfare](#), the media is [pivoting away](#) from climate journalism, and even activists are [urging a softer, more “hopeful” tone](#). It all signals a vibe shift in how we talk about climate change, reframing it from the existential risk it *actually* poses to a less urgent, peripheral issue—even as the floodwaters reach our front doors.

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Gates (whose climate nonprofit Breakthrough Energy [laid off dozens of staffers](#) earlier this year) is not incorrect to point out that “we’ve made great progress” in fostering climate solutions, and that [agriculture](#) and land use should be an especially urgent area of focus. But the person he’s targeting with his post—a government official cutting health and aid funding and redirecting it toward emissions reduction—doesn’t really exist, certainly not at this particular moment.

As the U.S. [pulls back on](#) all foreign aid [and health funds](#), to [devastating and fatal effect](#) across the Eastern Hemisphere, other rich nations are not filling in the gap but instead following suit, cutting back on climate, health, *and* [development](#). In the climate realm in particular, wealthier countries are trimming not just their budgets (e.g., clean-energy exports, startup financing) but even their assistance with long-term [adaptation to a warming Earth](#)—something Gates now prizes above mitigation. This despite the fact that the U.N. secretary-general warns that it is “[inevitable](#)” the world will overshoot the decade-old Paris Agreement’s goal of limiting warming to 1.5 degrees Celsius—as an explicit means of *preventing* worst-case scenarios that will require more money and resources to address. The world order that once notched international climate agreements isn’t just retreating from that fight; it’s pulling back from any globally minded responsibility altogether.

The inherent tension Gates posits between “quality of life” and “lowering emissions” is simply false—and it’s a favored talking point of climate denialists. The most odious exemplar of this may be the pro-fossil fuel activist Alex Epstein, whose books (which I’ve [reviewed critically](#)) frame the transition from oil and gas to renewables as an “anti-human” endeavor. These days, Epstein is deeply embedded with congressional Republicans, pushing behind the scenes for [the debilitating dents in U.S. clean-energy subsidies](#) that have been effected through this year’s budget bills.

Setting climate action as antithetical to human flourishing is plainly false; the devastated Caribbean citizens now rebuilding from Hurricane Melissa’s destruction would not be in this predicament had carbon emissions not overheated the ocean and messed with wind cycles. As for finances, [the climate is the economy](#): Skyrocketing [insurance and resource costs](#) in the region, along with [depleted agricultural yields](#), are not incidental to climate effects but a direct consequence of their fallout. At our current level of 1.3 degrees Celsius of warming above preindustrial levels, we see the crushing effects *everywhere*. It will not be any easier for island nations to recover as more extreme weather comes for their homes (and ours), and as nations of means shirk their [mandated responsibilities](#) to those spewing far fewer emissions, yet taking the biggest direct impacts.

The good news is, there are many folks on the ground working independently to advance climate solutions *and* their own welfare at the same time. Countries like [Pakistan](#) and Rwanda have put [cheap solar-panel imports](#) to great use—even to [help with growing food](#). In the Caribbean, some of the hospitals treating the wounded will be [powered by solar panels and battery storage](#), insulating them from the [ongoing electricity outages](#). The U.S. government planes that have been monitoring Melissa’s path are flown by pilots who [aren’t being paid to do so](#), thanks to the government shutdown. These are the types of admirable missions led by people who understand the situation at a far more intimate level than Bill Gates ever will.

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